for holding substantive negotiations. I told the group as emphatically as I could: The Strategic Defense Initiative was not a “bargaining chip” and we were going to stick with it no matter what the Russians wanted.

The SDI might take decades to develop, but what more important mission did we have than finding the means to neutralize the terrible weapons produced by the nuclear age?

I never viewed the SDI as an impenetrable shield—no defense could ever be expected to be one hundred percent effective.

But what made the idea promising was that, if it worked and we then entered an era when the nations of the world agreed to eliminate nuclear weapons, it could serve as a safety valve against cheating—or attacks by lunatics who managed to get their hands on a nuclear missile. And, if we couldn’t reach an agreement eliminating nuclear missiles, the system would be able to knock down enough of an enemy’s missiles so that if he ever pushed the button to attack, he would be doing so in the knowledge his attack was unable to prevent a devastating retaliatory strike. The SDI held too much potential for the security of mankind to be traded away at the negotiating table, I said.

I said at one meeting that I was getting fed up with the way the Russians were behaving and that too often in the past the United States had accepted flawed agreements with them simply because we couldn’t get any other kind of agreement. Afterward, I wrote in the diary: “I made it plain there must be no granting of concessions, one sided, to try to soften up the Soviets . . . we’re convinced they want above all to negotiate away our right to seek defensive weapons against ballistic missiles. They fear our technology. I believe such a defense could render nuclear weapons obsolete and thus we could rid the world of that threat. Question is, will they use that to break off the talks and